

HISTORICAL BRIEFING SHEET: HECK CHAPEL

Location: 202 East Broad Street, Griffin, GA

Property Owner: Griffin Downtown Development Authority (DDA)

DDA Purchase Intent: Blight mitigation and economic redevelopment of the Broad Street corridor.

National Register Status: Not registered.

Historical Era of Operation: 1864 – c. 2000

1. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY & SITE SIGNIFICANCE

Heck Chapel (historically **Heck Chapel United Methodist Church**) is a landmark historic site in downtown Griffin. Established immediately following Emancipation at the end of the Civil War, the church operated continuously for over 135 years (1864 through approximately 2000).

Beyond its status as the "**mother church**" of **African American Methodist congregations in Griffin**, the property holds profound municipal and state significance as a primary organizing hub during the Civil Rights Movement in Spalding County and the birthplace of the Griffin-Spalding branch of the NAACP.

2. CHRONOLOGICAL HISTORY & YEARS OF OPERATION

- **1864 – Establishment:** Prior to Emancipation, enslaved African Americans in Griffin were restricted to worshiping from the balcony of First Baptist Church. Near the close of the Civil War in 1864, freedmen established their own independent sanctuary at 202 East Broad Street.
- **Late 19th & Early 20th Century – Community Anchor:** The chapel served as a central spiritual, educational, and social anchor for newly freed families during Reconstruction and Jim Crow, providing mutual aid and civic support.
- **1950s–1960s – Civil Rights Headquarters:** Under the leadership of pastor **Rev. James Maynard Shopshire**, Heck Chapel became a vital organizational sanctuary during the Civil Rights Era:
 - **NAACP Founding:** Rev. Shopshire established the Griffin-Spalding branch of the **NAACP** at Heck Chapel.
 - **Direct Action & Civic Training:** The sanctuary hosted nonviolent protest trainings, youth leadership workshops, and voter registration drives aimed at expanding political rights for Black residents in Spalding County.

Note on Rev. Shopshire: Following his leadership in Griffin, Rev. Dr. Shopshire earned his Ph.D. from Northwestern University and became a distinguished theologian and Professor of Sociology of Religion and Urban Ministry at Wesley Theological Seminary.

- **c. 2000 – Active Operations Cease:** After more than 135 years of active congregational life, church services at the site concluded around 2000.

3. HISTORY OF THE NAME: WHO WAS BARBARA HECK?

In the Methodist Episcopal tradition, Black congregations established after the Civil War were often named in honor of prominent figures in Methodist history. Heck Chapel was named after **Barbara Heck (1734–1804)**, celebrated as the "**Mother of American Methodism.**"



Key Biographical Highlights:

- **Early Life:** Born Barbara Ruckle in County Limerick, Ireland, to German Palatine refugees. She converted to Methodism in 1752 under the preaching of John Wesley's movement and immigrated to New York in 1760.
- **Founding American Methodism (1766):** Concerned by the spiritual apathy of fellow immigrants, Heck famously implored local preacher Philip Embury to begin holding services. She organized the first Methodist meeting in America in Embury's home with just five attendees.
- **John Street Church (1768):** As the congregation grew, Heck helped design and raise funds for **Wesley Chapel** on John Street in New York City—the very first Methodist church building in the United States.
- **Canadian Legacy:** A Loyalist during the American Revolution, she later moved to Upper Canada (Ontario), where she founded Canada's first Methodist class. She died in 1804 while reading her Bible.